

Figure 4: Xerte packages



Figure 5: Mind mapping tools

on the client side. The Xerte developer edition needs to be installed on desktops. The Xerte flex compiler is for working with the Flex SDK. Another Xerte tool is Xpert, which is a repository for sharing learning objects and provides re-usability features. This serves as the publishing platform. The Xerte version can be downloaded from <http://www.nottingham.ac.uk/xerte/downloads.aspx>.

XMind

XMind is an open source mind mapping application. Though mind mapping has got applications in various domains, the benefits it provides to the teaching-learning process are incomparable. A mind map is a very effective tool for discussing and developing an idea or project plan. It can be used for the benefit of students to clearly illustrate an idea or a concept.

There exists an array of mind mapping tools, both proprietary and open source. A few of them are desktop versions and a few are browser-based. Here we take a look at XMind, the leading open source mind mapping tool.

XMind was developed by XMind Ltd and is a cross-platform tool. Apart from mind maps, it supports fishbone diagrams, tree diagrams and organisational charts. The latest release of XMind is version 6. In addition to the free versions, XMind also comes in Pro and Plus versions.

XMind has received various awards like 'The Best Project for Academia' from the Sourceforge community, the 'Most Popular Mind Mapping Software' from Lifehacker, etc.

XMind 6 has new features like a redesigned brainstorming mode, the ability to save to Evernote, index view, exporting to the Open Office ODF format, etc. It has also come up with more themes and styles. All the figures used in this article are created using XMind.

Another interesting aspect of XMind is its portability. It has a USB version that can be loaded into a USB pen drive

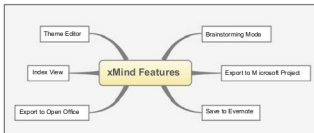


Figure 6: XMind's features

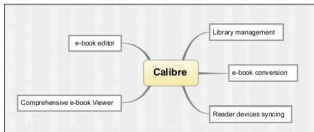


Figure 7: Calibre's features

and used with Windows, Mac or Linux environments.

Calibre

One of the typical problems that the academic community faces is organising the growing collections of ebooks, which has led to a problem of plenty. Calibre is an effective solution for this problem of managing an ebook library. It is free, open source and is loaded with features as illustrated in Figure 7.

The brain behind Calibre is Kovid Goyal. The popularity and benefits of Calibre can be understood from the installation statistics, which is more than 27 million. The current stable release is 2.15 (January 2015) and it is available in more than 35 languages. It can be downloaded from <http://calibre-ebook.com/download>. Calibre is cross-platform, and supports Windows, Linux and Mac. There is a portable version as well. Associated Android applications are also available for Calibre, developed by third party developers. **END** 

References

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